



Statement by President von der Leyen at the joint press conference with the Prime Minister of Kosovo, Albin Kurti

Pristina, 1 October 2026

Prime Minister Kurti, Dear Albin.

Thank you for welcoming me back to Pristina, for the sixth time. Kosovo is going through an important political moment. I want to start with the issue, that you touched upon at the end of your statement, that is understandably at the centre of public attention. Nothing and nobody can rewrite Kosovo's history. 1999 is engraved in Europe's collective memory. The violent repression. The humanitarian crisis. The suffering endured by your people. The EU has stood with you ever since. We have been Kosovo's strongest partner and largest provider of financial assistance. We have been supporting reconstruction. Economic development. Reforms. And the constitution of a modern, democratic Kosovo. A Kosovo whose future is in our Union.

The judgment of the Specialist Chambers has caused strong emotions. I appreciate your measured response, and that of other political leaders, calling for calm. This judgment was delivered by independent judicial institutions. And their mandate must be fully respected. The defendants now have the right to appeal. But one thing is clear. This judgment is about the individual responsibility of the defendants. Kosovo's resistance was not on trial. And we must honour the memory of all victims. From all communities in Kosovo. Their memory must remain part of Kosovo's path towards reconciliation and a shared future. This brings me to my second point: the crucial importance of institutional stability. The new Assembly and the government have been formed. The next step is the election of a President. We have seen in recent weeks and days that dialogue between political parties is possible. And you should build on it. Because institutional stability is the foundation for everything else. For reforms. For growth. And for progress on your European path.

This brings me to my third point: Kosovo's European future. I said it before and I will say it again: I believe in a European future for Kosovo. Because I know how deeply European the people of Kosovo feel. This is a strong foundation on which we must build. And our task is to turn this aspiration into concrete progress towards being a member of our Union. This is exactly what our Growth Plan is about. You know the principle – it is the same across the region. We bring more EU investment. And we progressively open parts of our Single Market to you. In parallel, you deliver the reforms needed, so that your companies can compete and thrive with the companies of the single market at a level playing field. This is how Kosovo's economy can gradually converge with the Single Market of the European Union. Kosovo can receive up to 882 million euro under the Growth Plan. And you have already received 62 million in pre-financing. But of course, more can come, and should come. But for this, we need an absolute surge in reforms. Bold reforms. Delivered fast. And we need fully functioning institutions.

The Growth Plan can take you significantly closer to our Single Market. It is up to you to seize the opportunities. Let me give you two examples: On roaming. Now that you have appointed your chief negotiator, we will start negotiations to bring down charges, as we are doing across the region. On SEPA: When you adopt the legislation needed to move forward, you can join SEPA, our Single Euro Payments Area. SEPA has the potential to save Western Balkan companies up to 500 million euro annually – a real boon for business, because it would reduce transaction fees and deliver payments faster. So, step by step, this is how Kosovo comes closer to the European Union.

Kosovo's European future is also about the kind of society it builds. Kosovo must protect its multi-ethnic character. And rebuild trust with the Kosovo-Serb community. We have seen positive steps this year, including on missing persons and the agreement of 14 March. And I thank you for that.

Dear Albin,

Next, I will visit the University of Pristina. And in particular, the Faculty of Mathematics and Natural Sciences and its new premises, that were built with European funds. I will meet the students who are shaping Kosovo's future. They are the ones who will drive innovation. They are the ones who will create companies. They are the ones who will create jobs and growth. And I hope, they will shape Kosovo's future in the European Union. Thank you for all that you have done. Thank you for your hospitality and I am very much looking forward to visiting the University of Pristina.

Thank you.

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